



G.A.M.M.A Protocol

S.T.A.L.K.E.R. Anomaly 1.5.3 + GAMMA

Modlist · Installation · Field Manual · Community Addons

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1 Installation

Everything you need to get from a clean Windows machine to a running GAMMA game: first a fresh *S.T.A.L.K.E.R. Anomaly 1.5.3*, then the GAMMA modpack on top of it.

Good to know

Two installs, in order: **1) Anomaly 1.5.3** — the standalone base game, free — and **2) GAMMA** — the modpack, assembled by its own launcher on top of Anomaly. Do not reorder or skip: GAMMA requires a fresh, untouched Anomaly 1.5.3.

1.1 Part 1 — S.T.A.L.K.E.R. Anomaly 1.5.3

Anomaly is a free, **standalone** modification of the original STALKER trilogy: it does not require owning *Shadow of Chernobyl*, *Clear Sky* or *Call of Pripjat*, and it installs completely independently of them. Version **1.5.3** is the current release and the only version GAMMA supports.

1.1.1 What you need

- Windows 10 or 11 (64-bit).
- Roughly **30 GB** of free disk space for Anomaly itself.
- **7-Zip** (7-zip.org) to extract the download — the built-in Windows archive tool can fail on these archives.
- No STALKER game ownership required.

1.1.2 Step 1 — Download

1. Open the official ModDB page: moddb.com/mods/stalker-anomaly.
2. Open the **Files** tab and download the **Anomaly 1.5.3** release — a single .7z archive of roughly 7–8 GB.
3. Download only from the official page. Unofficial mirrors and “repacks” are a common source of broken or fake installs.

1.1.3 Step 2 — Create the install folder

Create a clean folder for the game, for example `C:\Games\Anomaly`.

Watch out

Do **not** install into Program Files, Documents, Desktop, OneDrive folders or any user-profile path. Anomaly (and later GAMMA) writes saves, logs and configs around the install; protected, permission-restricted or synced locations cause crashes and save errors.

1.1.4 Step 3 — Extract

- Right-click the downloaded .7z → **7-Zip** → **Extract Here** into `C:\Games\Anomaly`.
- When finished, `AnomalyLauncher.exe` must sit at the top level of that folder — not inside a nested subfolder.

1.1.5 Step 4 — First launch and sanity check

1. Run `AnomalyLauncher.exe`.
2. In the launcher, pick your **renderer** (DX10 or DX11 — try DX11 first on modern hardware), resolution, and fullscreen or windowed mode.
3. Click **Launch**.
4. From the main menu, start a quick **New Game** and play for a minute or two to confirm everything runs.

1.1.6 Done — Anomaly is installed

Leave this install untouched from here on. GAMMA expects a **fresh, unmodified** Anomaly — no addons, no manual file edits.

1.2 Part 2 — GAMMA

G.A.M.M.A. (“Grok’s / Grokitach’s Automated Modular Modpack for Anomaly”) is a curated modpack of roughly **400 mods** that turns Anomaly into a hardcore survival sim. It is not shipped as a single mod file: a dedicated **GAMMA launcher** downloads and assembles the whole pack into its own Mod Organizer 2 (MO2) instance.

GAMMA updates frequently — the current release is **0.9.5** (May 2026); 0.9.3 shipped December 2024. Always check the official channels for the current version before installing.

1.2.1 Prerequisites

- A **fresh, untouched Anomaly 1.5.3** (Part 1).
- **150 GB of free disk space minimum** — 175–200 GB recommended. The final install is roughly 80–120 GB, but the installer needs extra room for downloads and extraction on top of that.
- **7-Zip** — the GAMMA installer relies on it; WinRAR and the Windows archive manager are known to cause extraction errors.
- .NET Framework 3.5, the latest DirectX, and the latest **Visual C++ x64 Redistributable** (Windows Update or the Microsoft download pages).
- Windows 10/11 64-bit and a stable internet connection — the installer downloads tens of gigabytes.

1.2.2 Folder plan

Use two **separate** folders, for example:

- Anomaly: C:\Games\Anomaly
- GAMMA: C:\Games\GAMMA

Watch out

Keep the folders separate — do not place one inside the other. Avoid Documents, Desktop and user-profile paths entirely. The installer moves and renames folders during setup, so nothing may be locked, protected or cloud-synced.

1.2.3 Antivirus exclusions

Add both folders to your antivirus exclusions, or pause real-time protection during the install. Windows Defender: **Settings** → **Privacy & Security** → **Windows Security** → **Virus & threat protection** → **Manage settings** → **Exclusions** → **Add a folder** — add C:\Games\Anomaly and C:\Games\GAMMA.

Tip

GAMMA writes hundreds of mod files in rapid succession; AV scanning mid-install is the #1 cause of “installer hangs” and corrupt installs.

1.2.4 Step 1 — Get the GAMMA installer

GAMMA is distributed through its own community channels — there is no ModDB download page for the pack itself:

- Official **GAMMA Discord**: discord.com/invite/stalker-gamma — the pinned messages of the installation/announcements channels hold the current installer.
- Official **GitHub wiki**: github.com/Grokitach/Stalker_GAMMA — step-by-step installation guide and links, if you prefer not to use Discord.

Watch out

Never download “GAMMA repacks” from third-party sites — they are outdated, broken, or worse. Only the files linked from the official Discord or GitHub wiki are supported.

1.2.5 Step 2 — Run the installer

1. Launch the downloaded GAMMA installer.
2. Point it at your **Anomaly 1.5.3** installation folder (C:\Games\Anomaly).
3. Choose the GAMMA folder (C:\Games\GAMMA) and let it run.
4. The installer downloads and assembles the modpack — this is the long step: from about an hour on fast connections to several hours on slower ones. Let it finish completely; do not close it early.
5. When done, the installer creates **desktop shortcuts**: the **GAMMA Launcher** and **Mod Organizer 2**.

Good to know

A faster alternative exists for some users: the **GOG one-click install** (available on the GOG store for owners of *Call of Pripyat* or *STALKER 2*, roughly 30–60 minutes). The manual launcher path above is the standard, fully supported route and the one this guide assumes.

1.2.6 Step 3 — First launch

1. Open the **GAMMA Launcher**.
2. Click **Update GAMMA data** (refreshes the pack's metadata), then **Install / Update GAMMA** — on a fresh install this verifies integrity and completes the assembly.
3. Launch the game through the launcher — it starts MO2 and runs Anomaly with the pack. The first boot compiles shaders and can take a long while: be patient and do not kill the process.

1.2.7 Step 4 — Configure before playing

In the GAMMA launcher you can set the **progression preset** before you ever enter the Zone:

- **Tourist** — generous task payouts; the recommended starting point (see the How to Play chapter).
- **Scavenger** — the middle ground; GAMMA's "standard" economy.
- **Survivalist** — the harshest economy; for veterans.

Combat difficulty is set separately in-game, so "Tourist economy + Medium or Hard combat" is a common first-run setup.

Tip

If you plan to use **ReShade**, keep the launcher option "**Delete Reshade**" unticked — otherwise the launcher wipes your ReShade files on update.

1.2.8 Updating GAMMA

- Open the GAMMA Launcher → **Update GAMMA data** → **Install / Update GAMMA**.
- Major updates (for example 0.9.3 → 0.9.5) frequently require a **new save game** — check the Discord announcements before updating, and never update mid-campaign without backing up your saves and MO2 profile.

1.2.9 Troubleshooting

- **Installer hangs or fails** — apply the antivirus exclusions above, free up disk space, re-run.
- **Launcher reports corrupt files** — run **Install / Update GAMMA** again; it verifies and repairs.
- **Game crashes on launch** — wrong renderer setting: switch between DX10 and DX11 in the launcher. Shader compilation on first boot is slow but must complete.
- **Save problems after an update** — start a new game per the update notes.
- Anything else — the GAMMA Discord help channels and #FAQ; with logs attached they solve things faster than any wiki.

1.3 Where to get help

- Anomaly: the ModDB page's comments and the broader STALKER community.

- GAMMA: the official GAMMA Discord — #installation, #faq and #help are the canonical support route.

2 The Modlist

What “G.A.M.M.A Protocol” actually consists of: the GAMMA modpack for Anomaly 1.5.3, and how it is organized.

2.1 The pack at a glance

Property	Value
Base game	S.T.A.L.K.E.R. Anomaly 1.5.3 (standalone, free)
Modpack	GAMMA — Grok’s / Grokitach’s Automated Modular Modpack for Anomaly
Mod count	Roughly 400 curated mods
Mod manager	Mod Organizer 2 (bundled and pre-configured by the installer)
Distribution	GAMMA Launcher — official Discord / GitHub wiki only
Version line	0.9.5 (May 2026) is current; 0.9.3 (Dec 2024) prior — check the Discord for anything newer
Install size	Roughly 80–120 GB after assembly
Playing style	Hardcore open-world survival sandbox with story missions

2.2 What GAMMA is

GAMMA is a heavily curated, modular overhaul. Its design goal is a long, immersive survival campaign: you start as a barely equipped stalker and claw your way up through scavenging, repairing and crafting — not through buying gear. Every system in Anomaly is rebalanced and extended: economy, health, ballistics, crafting, mutants, stashes, missions and visuals are all part of the pack.

Because it is assembled from hundreds of individual mods inside a pre-configured MO2 instance, the pack is both deeply customizable (you can disable or tweak individual mods) and sensitive to outside changes — which is why the Addons chapter stresses compatibility checks.

2.3 Design pillars

- **The “hobo phase”.** You begin with minimal gear and no way to simply buy your way out of it. Early hours are about surviving, looting and scraping together a usable loadout.
- **No gear from traders.** By default traders do not stock weapons or armor; they sell ammunition, consumables, junk and services. Everything shootable is found, looted, repaired or crafted. (This rule is toggleable in MCM if you want a softer economy.)
- **Repair is the progression.** Gear degrades and jams; you maintain it with oil and cleaning kits and repair it part-by-part with repair kits and scavenged parts. Better tools unlock better repairs and recipes.
- **Realistic danger.** Ballistics, health and radiation are tuned to be lethal: calibers matter, armor matters, headshots end fights, and untreated wounds stack up.
- **Expanded world.** More locations, quests, stashes, artifacts, mutant variants and AI behavior on top of Anomaly’s already large sandbox.

2.4 Systems overview

The pack is organized in MO2 by category; the full per-mod list lives there after install. At a system level, GAMMA delivers:

- **Health & survival** — limb-based damage (head, torso, arms, legs), bleeding, fractures, radiation, hunger, thirst, sleep, drugs and treatment items with real usage time.
- **Economy** — task payouts scaled by progression preset; trade in junk, parts, artifacts and ammo; no direct weapon/armor purchases by default.
- **Repair & crafting** — weapon parts and repair kits (kit types cover weapon classes, shown on the item), gun oil and cleaning kits, armor repair with sewing kits and textiles, ammunition reloading, medicine and food crafting, and a station-based crafting flow unlocked by **tool kits** (Basic, Advanced, Expert) delivered to technicians.
- **Weapons & gear** — hundreds of weapons across calibers, attachments and ammo types; armor from light jackets to exoskeletons; equipment upgrades through technicians.
- **World & content** — expanded stash economy, artifact systems with radiation trade-offs, more mutants and loot, improved A-Life squad behavior and faction dynamics.
- **Visuals & audio** — atmospheric overhaul (including Hippos Atmospherics and Screen Space Shaders as the rendering base), ReShade support, and a heavily retuned soundscape (including Oleh's Miscellaneous Sound Improvements); many other community audio mods are deliberately **not** included to protect that tuning.

Good to know

Gameplay systems and exact numbers drift between GAMMA versions. This guide describes how the systems **work** — for current values and recipes, open the Mod Configuration Menu (MCM) in-game and check the mod's own options.

2.5 Difficulty and progression presets

GAMMA separates **combat difficulty** from **progression difficulty**:

- Combat difficulty (Easy / Medium / Hard / Master) controls enemy accuracy, damage and aggression — set in-game at New Game or in settings.
- Progression difficulty (**Tourist** / **Scavenger** / **Survivalist**) controls the economy: how much tasks pay and how scarce resources are. It is chosen in the GAMMA launcher and is primarily about the speed of your rise, not the lethality of combat.

Tip

First run: Tourist progression + Medium or Hard combat. You still get the full GAMMA experience — lethal fights, scavenging, repair — without starving the economy.

The Mod Configuration Menu lets you fine-tune everything further: task payouts, buy/sell prices, loot durability, stash chances, the “no weapons in trader stock” rule and more. Tuning is expected; there is no “wrong” difficulty.

2.6 Warfare mode — an explicit caveat

Anomaly's third game mode, **Warfare**, reworks the whole Zone into a living faction battlefield. Within GAMMA it is generally **not** recommended: it is not well integrated with the pack's survival progression and can undermine the intended experience. Story or Sandbox are the supported ways to play GAMMA.

2.7 Download sources

Everything in this guide is downloaded from exactly two trusted hubs — never third-party repacks:

- **Anomaly 1.5.3**: **ModDB** — moddb.com/mods/stalker-anomaly (Files tab → 1.5.3 release).
- **GAMMA (the modpack itself)**: **official GAMMA Discord** — discord.com/invite/stalker-gamma (installer + current version) or the **official GitHub wiki** — github.com/Grokitach/Stalker_GAMMA.

- **Community addons:** see chapter 4 — each entry lists its own ModDB or Discord source.

2.8 Where the modlist lives

After installation, open **Mod Organizer 2** (desktop shortcut): the left pane lists every installed mod grouped by category, the right pane shows the load order. Treat this list as the source of truth for “what is in GAMMA”. Do not hand-edit or reorder the pack’s own mods — changes are best made through the launcher, MCM options, or carefully vetted addons (chapter 4).

3 How to Play

A field manual for surviving the Zone under GAMMA: from the New Game screen to exoskeleton endgame. GAMMA rebalances frequently, so this chapter teaches systems, routines and habits — not exact numbers. Current values live in the Mod Configuration Menu (MCM).

Good to know

What kind of game is this? An open-world survival sandbox with no hand-holding. You choose your faction, your goals and your pace; the Zone kills the careless. Expect to die, learn, and come back smarter. This chapter is long on purpose — read the sections you need, when you need them.

3.1 1. Starting out — the New Game screen

3.1.1 Choose a game mode

- **Story Mode** — the recommended way to learn: three sequential storylines (*Living Legend* → *Mortal Sin* → *Operation Afterglow*) with faction-specific missions woven in. New players should start here.
- **Sandbox Mode** — free play: your own goals, no main quest. Good for a second character or pure exploration.
- **Warfare Mode** — faction conquest sandbox. Under GAMMA this is generally not recommended (see the Modlist chapter).

3.1.2 Choose a faction

Your faction decides your starting location, gear, allies and enemies. Only some factions can play the main story:

Faction	Who they are	Story mode	GAMMA note
Loner	Independent stalkers of the Cor-don and Garbage	Yes	The classic first-run start; neutral enough to trade anywhere
Clear Sky	Swamp-based scholar-warriors studying the Zone	Yes	Harder swamp start; good for players who know Anomaly
Ecologist	Scientists in advanced anomaly-resistant armor	Yes	Strong gear, weaker combat focus
Mercenary	Guns for hire in the south	Yes	Hostile to several factions; careful trading
Freedom	Anti-military, Zone-open ideology	Yes	Allies in the north-west; enemies in the east

Duty	Militaristic anti-mutant order	Yes	The mirror of Freedom: strong bases, many enemies
Military	Army regulars	No	Extremely hostile world; veteran pick
Bandit	Criminals of the Garbage	No	High risk, high reward looting
Renegade	Outcast rabble at the truck cemetery	No	Hardest early economy
Sin	Zone-worshipping cultists	No	Isolated; few friends anywhere
Monolith	Zealots of the Zone's center	No	Everyone shoots you on sight; expert territory
UNISG	International task force	Own storyline (<i>Hollow Boundaries</i>)	Unique campaign with a different perspective

3.1.3 Choose your difficulty and loadout

- **Combat difficulty** — Medium or Hard is a good first run. Easy keeps fights forgiving while you learn survival.
- **Progression preset** — set in the GAMMA launcher: **Tourist** for your first character.
- **Starting loadout** — pick something light; you will replace everything within a few hours anyway. A pistol or shotgun, a knife, a sleeping bag and basic meds are a fine kit.

3.2 2. Interface and controls

The HUD shows health, stamina, weight, ammo and your quick-use slots. The **PDA** (map + journal) is your best friend: it holds mission markers, stash notes and zone intel.

Action	Default key(s)
Move	W A S D
Look	Mouse
Fire / Aim	LMB / RMB
Reload	R
Interact / Use	F
Jump	SPACE
Crouch	C
Sprint (hold)	SHIFT
Weapon slots	1 – 5
Inventory	I or TAB
Map / PDA	M
Quicksave	F5

Good to know

Defaults differ slightly between Anomaly and GAMMA builds and are fully remappable in **Options** → **Controls**. Gadget toggles (flashlight, night vision, binoculars, detector) are bound there too, and GAMMA adds extra bindings visible in **MCM**. Laptops often need **[FN] + [F5]** for quicksave.

3.2.1 The Mod Configuration Menu (MCM)

Open the pause menu → **Mod Configuration Menu**. This is GAMMA's control panel: every included mod exposes its options here — economy sliders, loot rates, repair settings, audio, crosshair, and dozens more. When a guide or the Discord tells you to “change X”, it is almost always in MCM.

3.3 3. A day in the Zone — the core loop

GAMMA is best played as a routine, not a series of sprints. A healthy day looks like this:

1. **Wake up** at your base or camp; eat and drink; check your condition.
2. **Plan the route**: open the PDA, pick one or two tasks that lie in the same direction, check the weather (rain hurts visibility; night raises mutant activity).
3. **Gear check**: enough meds and bandages, ammo for the caliber you carry, food and water, a detector if you plan to hunt artifacts — and **gun oil** so your weapon does not jam mid-fight.
4. **Travel carefully**: bolt suspicious ground, stay off roads when possible, listen more than you look.
5. **Complete the objective**: loot what is worth carrying, strip parts from ruined weapons, mark useful stashes on the PDA.
6. **Return before dusk** or before an emission — being caught outside in either is how stashes are made.
7. **At base**: sell junk, repair and clean your gear, craft supplies, rest. Accept new tasks.

Tip

Every hour you survive teaches you one more rule of the Zone. The loop above is the frame; the rules are the content. When in doubt, do the boring thing: it is usually the alive thing.

3.4 4. Your first 90 minutes (Loner start)

A concrete walkthrough of the opening, using the classic Loner start in the Cordon:

1. **Spawn in** — you begin near the Rookie Village with a basic kit. Open the PDA and read the tutorial hints; they are short and worth it.
2. **Talk to the trader** — accept a simple task or two (killing mutants near the village, fetching an item). Do not wander north yet.
3. **Scavenge the immediate area** — loot bodies from recent fights, search stashes and containers. Most early weapons drop broken; that is fine, parts have value.
4. **Do your first tasks** — a few boars or dogs with a shotgun or pistol is a fair fight. Collect mutant parts; they sell and craft.
5. **Return and sell** — junk, spare parts and duplicate meds become money. Buy ammo, meds and a better detector.
6. **Learn to clean your gun** — apply gun oil after every outing; a clean weapon is a reliable weapon.
7. **Rest** — sleep, save (**[F5]**), and take stock. You are now a functioning stalker. From here, push into the Garbage when you feel ready.

Watch out

The single most common first-hour death is wandering into the military checkpoint zone at the north of the Cordon. Watch the PDA map for red hostility, listen for gunfire ahead, and turn around if the firefight sounds too big for you.

3.5 5. Health and survival — deep dive

3.5.1 The statuses that kill you

Status	Caused by	Treatment
Bleeding	Bullets, mutants, anomalies	Bandages (multiple for heavy bleeding); medkits after the bleeding stops
Fracture	Falls, melee, explosives	Splint; movement and aim recover as it heals
Radiation	Artifacts, contaminated ground, some anomalies	Anti-rad drugs; leave the source; lead containers for artifacts
Chemical burn	Acid anomalies and weapons	Anti-chemical treatment; wash and treat the affected limb
Psy damage	Psi anomalies, controllers	Psi-blockers; break line of sight to the source
Hunger / thirst	Time passing	Food and water; carry more than you think you need
Fatigue	Time passing, sprinting, carrying weight	Sleep — a sleeping bag anywhere safe, or a bed at a base

3.5.2 The rules of treating yourself

- **Treat in cover.** Bandaging takes time and leaves you vulnerable. Get behind a wall before you patch up.
- **Bleeding first, health second.** Medkits restore HP but do not stop bleeding; bandages stop bleeding but do not restore much HP. Use both, in that order.
- **Read the item card.** GAMMA's medical items are specific: the right tool for the right status, and often a use-time to respect.
- **Armor is your health bar.** A suit in good condition absorbs hits that would otherwise shred your limbs. A wrecked suit makes every fight a gamble.

3.6 6. Radiation and artifacts

3.6.1 Radiation basics

Radiation builds up from contaminated ground, artifact handling and certain anomalies. Watch the Geiger counter:

- **Low exposure** — treat with anti-rad drugs; keep moving.
- **High exposure** — find shelter, use stronger treatment, and **remove the source** (drop the artifact into a container, leave the field).
- **Carry containers.** Lead-lined artifact containers are the correct way to haul glowing loot — an artifact loose in your bag irradiates you continuously.

3.6.2 The artifact hunt — a workflow

1. **Bring a detector** — the basic **Echo**, the better **Bear**, the best **Veles**. Better detectors see further and mark fainter fields.
2. **Read the field** — artifacts spawn inside anomaly fields. Observe the pattern of the anomalies first; find the safe lanes.
3. **Probe with bolts** — throw a bolt to test the path before you commit to it.
4. **Detect and triangulate** — sweep with the detector; the signal strengthens as you approach. The artifact is usually near the field's center.
5. **Grab it quickly** — snatch the artifact and retreat along your probed path. Do not linger in the field.

6. **Containerize or sell** — artifacts radiate; keep them in containers. Decide: sell for money, keep for crafting, or equip for stats.

Tip

After every **emission**, anomaly fields reshuffle and new artifacts can spawn. An experienced stalker's best payday is a well-known field right after an emission.

3.7 7. Anomalies and the Zone

3.7.1 Anomaly encyclopedia

Class	Examples	How to survive it
Gravitational	Whirligigs, springboards	They crush and fling; watch for shimmering air and dead grass rings; walk around, never through
Thermal	Fireballs, burner fields	Heat haze and scorched ground; a burst of fire damage — keep distance and do not stand still
Electrical	Electro arcs, spark fields	Blue crackling; discharges on approach — time your crossing between arcs or go around
Chemical	Acid pools, corrosive clouds	Green pools and fumes; chemical burn damage — use the gas-mask/SEVA suits for protection
Psi	Psi fields, some structures	Disorientation, psy damage; psi-blockers help; break line of sight to the emitter

The Zone's first rule: **bolt first, walk second**. Throw a bolt (a keybound gadget) to probe a suspicious patch before walking through it. Every field has a pattern — learn the safe lanes and the artifact spawn points inside.

3.7.2 Emissions — the protocol

Watch out

An **emission** is the Zone's periodic purge: a warning flashes on the PDA, the sky turns red, and lethal radiation sweeps the map for a couple of minutes. The moment you see the warning, get **indoors** — a building or bunker — and wait it out. Do not try to outrun it in the open. After an emission the world resets: anomaly fields reshuffle and new artifacts can spawn.

3.8 8. Mutants

The Zone's wildlife is uniformly hostile. Learn their behavior and match your weapons to the threat:

Mutant	Behavior	Tactics
Flesh	Pig-like; flees when hurt	Any weapon; a shotgun settles them cheaply
Boar	Charges in a straight line	Sidestep the charge, then fire into the flank

Blind dogs / pseudo-dogs	Fast packs	Keep moving, headshots; never stand still
Snorks	Leaping melee attackers	Distance and sustained fire; they close fast
Bloodsucker	Cloaks, strikes melee	Listen for the growl, keep moving, burst fire — do not fight it with a pistol
Controller	Psi stare at range	Break line of sight and retreat, or finish it fast with heavy rounds
Burer	Telekinesis; throws objects, yanks weapons	Surprise and burst damage; recover your weapon after the yank
Chimera	Fast, armoured, lethal	Heavy calibers, explosives, an escape route — or avoid it entirely
Pseudogiant	Tank that stomps	Explosives and sustained heavy fire; run if outgunned

Good to know

GAMMA expands the bestiary and lets you **loot mutant parts** — hides, meat and organs used in crafting. Skin what you kill; the parts sell and feed your crafting loop.

3.9 9. Weapons, ammo and ballistics

3.9.1 Caliber guide

Caliber	Typical guns	Role
9x18 PM	PM, PP-91	Cheap starter pistols; weak against armor
9x19	Western pistols and SMGs	Better sidearms and early SMGs
.45 ACP	Heavy pistols	Hard-hitting sidearms; rare ammo
9x39	AS Val, VSS, SR-3	Subsonic and quiet; AP options; special forces gear
5.45x39	AK-74 family	The Zone's workhorse — common, light, plentiful ammo
5.56x45	AR family	Accurate, modular; ammo less common in the south
7.62x39	AKM	Harder-hitting than 5.45; heavier ammo
7.62x54R	SVD, PKM	Sniping and suppression; one-shot power on soft targets
12 gauge	Shotguns	King of close range and mutant control
12.7x55	VKS	Endgame anti-armor sniper; very rare

3.9.2 Ammo types

- **FMJ (ball)** — the standard round; fine against unarmoured targets.

- **AP (armor-piercing)** — defeats armor; costs more, does less tissue damage. Carry it for armored enemies.
- **Expanding / hollow point** — more damage to flesh, poor against armor. Perfect for mutants.
- **Tracer / subsonic / specialty** — situational; GAMMA adds more types, so read the item card.

Tip

Match the round to the target: AP for armored stalkers and Monolith, expanding for mutants and unarmored bandits. Carrying two ammo types for your main gun is standard practice.

3.9.3 Ballistics reality

- **Headshots end fights.** Torso shots grind through armor; leg shots cripple movement.
- **Gun condition is everything.** A dirty, degraded gun jams, drifts and spreads. Clean it with gun oil and cleaning kits; repair parts before they break.
- **Suppressors work.** Quiet shots keep engagements one-sided; noise draws the Zone to you.
- **Zeroing and scopes matter at range.** Know your optic, range your target.

3.10 10. Armor and protection

Armor class	Examples	Strengths / weaknesses
Light	Leather jacket, windbreaker	Cheap, light, near-useless against bullets; fine against dogs
Light combined	CS-1/2, stalker suits	Modest bullet and anomaly protection; the early-mid workhorse
Heavy / combined	Bulat, military and merc armor	Serious ballistic protection; heavier, slower, costlier to repair
Exoskeleton	Exoskeletons	Top ballistic and mutant protection; heavy, no sprint until upgraded
SEVA / ecologist	SEVA suits	Best anomaly, chemical and radiation protection; weaker against bullets

- **Maintain your suit** — repair with sewing kits, textiles and armor parts; a suit in poor condition protects like paper.
- **Upgrade via technicians** — suits take upgrades (pockets, protection, movement) using parts; the technician's tool tier gates what is available.
- **Match suit to mission** — artifact hunting favors anomaly protection; fighting favors ballistic protection; a good stalker owns both.

3.11 11. Combat tactics

- **Cover, burst fire, reposition.** Standing still and trading shots is how stalkers become stashes.
- **Use your gadgets** — binoculars to scout, night vision to own the dark, the detector to avoid surprises.
- **Grenades are gold** — scarce and loud; they clear rooms and mutant packs. Save them for the right moment.
- **Stealth is a weapon** — silencers, slow movement and angles keep fights one-sided.
- **Know when to run** — every rule of the Zone has an exception called “alive”.

3.12 12. Scavenging and inventory

- **Loot everything useful** — bodies carry weapons, parts, ammo, meds and junk. Weapons usually drop in pieces and poor condition; that is fine, parts are the real prize.
- **Weight discipline** — overburdening drains stamina and speed. Decide what is worth carrying; stash the rest.
- **Backpacks** — larger carrying bags exist as equipment; upgrading your carry capacity is a real early-game power spike.
- **Sort as you loot** — keep a mental “sell pile” (junk, spare parts, duplicates) and a “keep pile” (ammo for your calibers, meds, tools). It saves trips.

3.13 13. Repair and crafting — the heart of GAMMA

Everything you wear and shoot degrades, and **you** are the repair shop.

3.13.1 Weapons

- **Parts** — every weapon is made of parts (receiver, barrel, magazine, and so on). Looted weapons yield spare parts.
- **Repair kits** — typed kits (Type A/B/C/D, covering weapon classes) repair the matching part of a matching weapon. The type you need is shown on the item.
- **Cleaning** — **gun oil** and cleaning kits keep condition up and stop parts from degrading; a clean gun jams far less.
- **Assembly** — with enough parts and kits you can build a weapon from scratch. This is how you graduate from a rusty pistol to a rifle.

3.13.2 Armor

Suits work the same way: repaired with **sewing kits**, **textiles** and armor parts; maintained so ballistic and anomaly protection stays high.

3.13.3 Tools and technicians

Tool kits — **Basic**, **Advanced**, **Expert** — are the key progression items. They are found in stashes, increasingly in the dangerous north, and **delivered to technicians**. Each tier unlocks better repair kits and more crafting recipes. Befriending technicians (do their tasks) is the fastest way to grow.

3.13.4 Crafting

At base crafting stations you can make meds, food, ammunition (reload from casings), attachments and gear — recipes gated by the tool tiers you have unlocked. Scavenged parts and mutant materials feed into all of it.

Watch out

Do not hoard a ruined weapon “for later” — unless you have the parts and kits, it is dead weight. Dismantle it into useful parts instead.

3.14 14. Economy and missions

- **Traders** sell ammunition, consumables, food, junk and services — but no weapons or armor by default. They also **buy** your looted junk, parts and artifacts.
- **Money flows out** (ammo, meds, repairs, fast travel) and comes in from **tasks** — the honest economy loop is: loot → sell → buy consumables → repeat.
- **Task types** — hunt mutants, deliver items, retrieve artifacts, recon areas, escort or rescue. Pay scales with the progression preset; risk should scale with pay.
- **Reputation** — completing tasks raises standing with a faction, unlocking better prices, services and gear availability; shooting friendlies does the opposite. Keep your reputation intact where you shop.

- **Guides** — NPCs at bases who fast-travel you across the Zone for money. Worth every ruble when crossing hostile territory.

3.15 15. Stashes and safehouses

- **Stashes** are hidden loot caches — some marked on the PDA by task-givers, some found by chance or rumour. They hold tools, parts, documents and meds; they are the best early-game progression.
- **Personal stashes** — boxes at friendly bases store your surplus. Use them: the Zone is long, and you will come back for that spare suit.
- **Safehouses** — some buildings are safe to sleep and save in. Learn which ones; a safe bed beats a sleeping bag in the bushes.

3.16 16. A-Life and factions — how the world lives

- **A-Life** simulates the Zone around you: squads patrol, hunt, fight and die — on and off screen. Gunfire in the distance is a real fight with real loot on the ground afterward.
- **Faction wars** — Duty and Freedom skirmish, bandits raid, military sweeps. Neutral ground shifts; check the PDA's faction map before crossing "safe" roads.
- **Disguises** — wearing an enemy faction's armor can fool distant patrols. It does not survive close inspection or a scan — keep your distance and your story straight.
- **Your reputation is social capital.** In GAMMA, money buys consumables, but standing buys trust, prices and access. Spend both wisely.

3.17 17. Navigation and travel

- The **PDA map** is your compass: mission markers, known stashes, faction territory. Set waypoints and use the compass.
- The Zone is one continuous open world — no loading screens between regions. Travel is on foot or via guides.
- **North is harder.** The Cordon and Garbage are gentle; Zaton, Jupiter and the north (Pripyat, the CNPP) demand better gear, meds and radiation protection. Do not wander north in a leather jacket.

3.18 18. The progression arc

- **The hobo phase (first hours)** — pistol or shotgun, light suit, barely enough meds. Scavenge, do tasks, clean your gun, learn the Zone's rules.
- **The survivor phase** — assault rifles, decent armor, Advanced tools, your own crafting loop. You start choosing engagements instead of fleeing them.
- **The veteran phase** — exoskeleton or SEVA suit, artifact loadout, high-caliber rifles, northward expeditions. The Zone's best loot — and hardest threats — is now yours to take.

3.19 19. How to die less — a field checklist

Cause of death	Prevention
Emission in the open	Drop everything, run to the nearest building the moment the warning fires
Wandering into hostile territory	Check the PDA faction map; follow the gunfire with your ears before your feet
Jammed gun in a fight	Clean and repair your weapon at the end of every outing
Bleeding out without bandages	Carry more bandages than feels sensible; treat in cover

Artifact radiation death	Containers, containers, containers
Night ambushes	Sleep through the worst hours, or fight with night vision on your side
Over-encumbrance	Stash the surplus; a fast stalker is a live stalker
Rushing the north	Progress by gear, not by curiosity

3.20 20. Tips for new stalkers

1. **Start on Tourist.** You are learning systems, not proving anything.
2. **Quicksave often** (**F5**) — before fights, anomalies and long walks. Death is cheap; losing progress is not.
3. **Do not sprint everywhere** — stamina is life, and noise attracts trouble.
4. **Keep your gun clean.** A jammed rifle at the wrong moment is a corpse.
5. **Learn anomaly patterns before hunting artifacts** — bolts are cheaper than medkits.
6. **Run from bloodsuckers early.** There is no shame in living to loot another day.
7. **Use MCM.** Every frustration (economy, loot, audio, crosshair) has a lever there.
8. **Stash, do not carry everything.** Your base is your bank.
9. **Do tasks for technicians first** — tools are the real level-ups.
10. **Respect emissions.** The warning is not a suggestion.

3.21 21. Common mistakes

- **Buying gear from traders** — they do not sell weapons/armor by default; spend on ammo and meds instead.
- **Selling all your parts** — repair needs parts; keep a working stock.
- **Heading north too early** — radiation and mutants will eat a hobo loadout.
- **Ignoring hunger/sleep/radiation** — the HUD lies; the Geiger counter does not.
- **Hand-editing the mod list** — use MCM, the launcher, or vetted addons (next chapter).

4 Community Addons

Extending GAMMA beyond its 400 integrated mods — a short, moderated list of addons with real download sources, and how to add them without breaking the pack.

4.1 Moderation policy — what belongs in this list

This guide applies strict moderation to addons, the same way the pack itself is curated:

- **Cosmetic and quality-of-life only.** Audio, visuals and presets — nothing that changes balance, gear or economy.
- **No overpower.** Nothing that hands out free money, stats, weapons or god-mode effects.
- **No redundant.** If GAMMA already includes it (check MO2), it is not listed.
- **No conflicting.** Any addon known to clash with the pack is excluded outright — not “installed with caution”.
- **No adult or graphic themes.** The Zone is grim enough on its own.
- **Every entry below has a verifiable download source** — a ModDB page or the official GAMMA Discord. Anything that only exists as a dead or unstable link is not listed.

4.2 The golden rules

Watch out

- **Use the bundled Mod Organizer 2.** Never drop files into the Anomaly or GAMMA folders by hand — the pack's load order is how mods stay compatible.
- **Check compatibility first.** Search the GAMMA Discord for the addon's name before installing; if a compatibility patch exists, it is usually linked there.
- **Prefer DLTX-based addons.** DLTX addons patch data without overwriting files — they are dramatically safer inside GAMMA than mods that replace core files.
- **Back up your MO2 profile** before big changes (the profile lives in the GAMMA folder; a simple copy of the folder is enough).
- **Expect the launcher to reset manual changes** when you run **Install / Update GAMMA** — re-check your addons after updating.
- **Fewer, well-chosen addons beat a full load order.** Every extra mod is a new conflict surface.

4.3 How to install any addon

1. **Download** the addon archive (.7z or .zip) from the source listed on its card.
2. Open **Mod Organizer 2** (desktop shortcut created by the GAMMA installer).
3. Drag the archive into MO2's **Downloads** tab, or click the **"Install a new mod from an archive"** button (the disc icon) and select the file.
4. Follow any install prompts; give the mod a clear name.
5. **Tick the checkbox** in the left pane to enable it, and place it in the load order where the addon's instructions (or the Discord) say — usually above the GAMMA group it modifies.
6. Launch the game **through MO2** (Run) and test in a quick session.
7. To revert, untick the mod — or restore your profile backup for bigger rollbacks.

Tip

Keep the addon's readme and the Discord thread open while testing. "It loads" is not the same as "it works" — test the feature the addon changes.

4.4 Audio

Audio Expansion

AUDIO

Expands the Zone's ambient and environmental soundscape — weather, distant activity and atmospheric layers that make the world feel alive.

Where: ModDB — [Anomaly addons](#) (search "Audio Expansion") or the GAMMA Discord addons channel

Install: Standard MO2 install; often paired with RETUNE Ambience Sounds (same search). Verify no overlap with GAMMA's own ambient tuning.

Risk: Low-moderate; audio-only, but check the Discord for the version tested against current GAMMA.

RETUNE Ambience Sounds

AUDIO

Refines the background environmental audio — more natural wind, weather and distance layers. Frequently paired with Audio Expansion.

Where: ModDB — moddb.com/mods/stalker-anomaly/addons/retune-ambience-sounds

Install: Standard MO2 install. Some users find wind volume strong — tune audio settings or the mod's config if so.

Risk: Low; audio-only. Check the Discord for the version tested against current GAMMA.

Good to know

Weapon-sound addons are deliberately absent from this list. GAMMA ships a heavily tuned soundscape (including Oleh's Miscellaneous Sound Improvements), and the classic weapon-audio packs — JSRS and Dark Signal among them — are either discontinued or known to clash with it, producing silent weapons or crashes. Per the moderation policy they are excluded, not recommended.

4.5 Weapons & weapon visuals

Kmack's weapon projects (individual mods)

WEAPONS

High-quality weapon models, re-skins and animations (e.g. CAR-15, Walther PPQ, G3 and MP5 reworks) by a well-known community modder.

Where: [GAMMA Discord](#) — the #mods-postings channel, where the author posts current files

Install: Standard MO2 install per weapon. Before adding one, search MO2 and the Discord: much of Kmack's work is already integrated into GAMMA — skip anything already present.

Risk: Low when the weapon is not already in the pack; redundant otherwise.

Good to know

BoomSticks and SharpSticks (BaS) — the classic premium weapon pack — is not listed: GAMMA already integrates or supports it, so installing it separately is redundant and risks duplicating weapon assets. Check MO2 before adding any weapon mod.

4.6 UI & quality of life

DynaHUD

UI

A HUD manager that shows elements (health, stamina, radiation) only when they matter — cleaner screen, more immersion.

Where: [ModDB](#) — [Anomaly addons](#) (search “DynaHUD”)

Install: Standard MO2 install. GAMMA has community compatibility patches for DynaHUD — use the one linked in the Discord rather than the bare version.

Risk: Moderate without the patch; low with it. GAMMA ships its own HUD tweaks, so verify the patch exists for your version first.

Scopes as Binoculars

UI / QoL

Lets you use an equipped weapon scope as binoculars — saves inventory space and makes scouting feel natural.

Where: [ModDB](#) — [Anomaly addons](#) (search “Scopes as Binoculars”)

Install: Standard MO2 install.

Risk: Low; behaviour-only, no balance changes.

Good to know

Quick Action Wheel is not listed: it is already included in GAMMA by default (right-click an item in your inventory to add it to the wheel; manage it in MCM). Downloading it again would be redundant.

4.7 Graphics & environment

CCon Grass n Trees

VISUALS

Denser, more realistic grass and tree models; praised for keeping vegetation low enough that loot and mutants stay visible.

Where: [ModDB — Anomaly addons](#) (search “CCon Grass n Trees”)

Install: Standard MO2 install; pick the season variant you prefer. Check the Discord for a GAMMA-tested version or patch.

Risk: Low–moderate; the +FPS/performance variants exist for weaker rigs.

Glossy Puddles

VISUALS

Adds screen-space reflections to wet surfaces — puddles and ground genuinely glisten after rain.

Where: [GAMMA Discord](#) — addons channel; the most reliable source for the current version

Install: Standard MO2 install; works on top of GAMMA's Screen Space Shaders.

Risk: Low; expect a small FPS dip (roughly 5–10) during heavy rain on mid-range GPUs.

Nicer Flashlights and Headlamps

VISUALS

Better flashlight and headlamp visuals — realistic beam shape and intensity for night play.

Where: [ModDB — Anomaly addons](#) (search “Nicer Flashlights and Headlamps”)

Install: Standard MO2 install.

Risk: Low; cosmetic lighting only.

Good to know

Full texture overhauls such as **Rotten Life 3.0** are excluded by policy: the author frequently pulls the ModDB pages (no stable download source) and comprehensive texture packs overlap and conflict with GAMMA's own texture work. The visual addons above are additive rather than replacement-heavy for the same reason.

4.8 Performance

Before installing anything, tune what is already there — the biggest frame-rate wins in GAMMA are settings, not mods:

- Lower the **shadow map resolution** (e.g. 1536) — one of the most effective FPS gains with minimal visual impact.
- Use **SSDO on medium** instead of HBAO/HDAO.
- Disable **grass shadows** — a significant performance killer.
- Disable **water reflections** if you need more headroom.
- Pick the **+FPS variants** of any ReShade preset, and use the launcher's Reshade toggle to test with it off.
- Search “performance textures” on the Anomaly ModDB addons page for **1k / VRAM-light texture packs** if you are GPU-limited.

Watch out

Engine-level patches — **AO Engine**, **ALAO** or custom “modded EXEs” — are excluded by policy: they replace the game executables, and GAMMA already ships its own engine optimizations. Overwriting them conflicts with the pack's build and can be reverted by the launcher's integrity check. If you want more performance, tune the settings above first.

GAMMA's rendering base (Hippos Atmospherics + Screen Space Shaders) is already strong; ReShade presets add a final cinematic grade without touching game files.

4.8.1 Installing ReShade itself

1. Run the **ReShade installer** and choose the Anomaly executable (it lives in the Anomaly folder's bin directory).
2. Select the **DirectX 10/11** API when asked.
3. In-game, open the ReShade menu with the **Home** key and load a preset.

4.8.2 Installing a preset

1. Download a preset .ini from its source.
2. Drop it into the Anomaly game folder (next to the executable) — or wherever the preset's readme says.
3. In-game: **Home** → preset dropdown → select it.

Watch out

Keep “**Delete Reshade**” unticked in the GAMMA launcher settings, or the launcher removes your ReShade installation on update.

ZeN Summer / ZeN Winter presets

RESHADE

Frequently updated cinematic color grades for summer and winter zones — polished look without heavy performance cost; +FPS variants exist.

Where: [GAMMA Discord](#) — addons channel / community guides

Install: Drop the `.ini` into the Anomaly folder, load via the Home menu.

Risk: Low; pure post-processing. Pick the +FPS variant on weaker rigs.

Good to know

The **GAMMA Reshade Database** — a community-maintained spreadsheet usually linked in the GAMMA Discord — is the best way to browse dozens of tested presets and pick one matching your taste and hardware. **Emergent Zone** is not listed separately: it is already available through GAMMA's own ecosystem, so downloading it again would be redundant.

4.9 Finding more addons

- **GAMMA Discord** — the addons channels are the primary hub: community addons, patches, and compatibility threads. Search before you install.
- **ModDB** — **Anomaly addons section** (moddb.com/mods/stalker-anomaly/addons) — filter by Anomaly 1.5.3 compatibility; check the Discord for GAMMA-specific patches.
- **Community guides and YouTube** — useful for inspiration; always verify a mod against the Discord before trusting a video's load order.

Tip

The best “addon” on most GAMMA installs is not a mod at all: it is a tuned **MCM profile** and a **ReShade preset** you like. Get those right before stacking more files.